



## MONTHLY UPDATE

# South Africa: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-04 · 14 systems and instruments tracked, 12 of them not held

*Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-04 – July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.*

## Summary of the month

Two spectrum instruments were gazetted, the national artificial-intelligence policy changed from a rule-making instrument to a guidance one, and the Western Cape High Court struck down part of the birth-registration regulations. On delivery, a Public Service Commission investigation found [more than R2bn in irregular expenditure](#) at the State Information Technology Agency, which was [given 30 days to produce a recovery plan](#). Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report of 31 July recorded the single citizen application at [production-ready pilot](#), dated the next milestones to September 2026 and stated that progress had been uneven.

## Infrastructure

The [National Radio Frequency Plan 2026](#), approved by the minister on 2 July, was gazetted on 24 July and realigns the allocation table from 8.3kHz to 3,000GHz to the ITU Radio Regulations and to the SADC and African Telecommunications Union plans. The [IMT Roadmap 2026](#) was published for consultation the same day; its tables record 794MHz assigned to licensees and 18,831MHz still to be assigned. The regulator's accompanying statement of an increase from 850MHz to at least 18,588MHz by 2030, and of a 215% rise in high-demand spectrum, does not appear in the gazetted text; the two accounts have not been reconciled. Allocation of the 6GHz band was [deferred pending a feasibility study](#).

Herotel, a domestic provider with more than 350,000 customers, was [named Amazon Leo's South African distributor](#) for a 2027 launch. Starlink [began service in its 27th African country](#) and remains unlicensed in South Africa; the department told Parliament its draft satellite policy direction was ["of general application and not directed at any specific operator"](#). The state-backed [BrainSAT](#) venture launched on Emirati infrastructure.

Cape Town's municipal planning tribunal [approved two Equinix data centres](#) over objections from three civil-society organisations; the application disclosed neither water nor electricity demand, both deferred to the site development plan. Reuters put the planned load at about 170MW. NTT Data South Africa confirmed it had [sold seven facilities and leased them back](#). Google held its first African cloud summit in Johannesburg and announced an Eastern Cape exchange port; the President welcomed hyperscaler commitments while [stating that government is building its own cloud through the CSIR](#).

## Digital public infrastructure

Absa [joined the bank-branch smart identity channel](#), which the department put at 296 branches and more than 385,000 applications in four months; Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report gave 203,887 applications across 171 branches. The reference periods differ and the figures have not been reconciled. Mobile operators and the justice department agreed a framework to [replace document presentation in SIM registration with real-time departmental verification](#).

Home Affairs reported [377,060 identity numbers still blocked](#) and stated it could not trace approximately 400,000 of those affected, against a court deadline extended to March 2027. On 29 July the Western Cape High Court [held four categories of exclusion in the birth-registration regulations unconstitutional](#), allowing 18 months for amendment and holding that the orders required no Constitutional Court confirmation.

Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report of 31 July recorded an update under way to the [Minimum Interoperability Standards and the Government-Wide Enterprise Architecture](#), with an update due September 2026. The same report recorded the Payments Ecosystem Modernisation programme moving beyond conceptual design into active development of a payment credential, wallet, governance and trust capabilities, with testing against government use cases dated November 2026. Nothing held states how that rail relates to the bank-API rails below.

On 3 August the single citizen application was reported as a [production-ready pilot](#), its first credential use case a digital matric certificate built with Umalusi, with the verification approach in testing.

The Reserve Bank gazetted a [national interoperable payment code standard](#), with PayShap the first rail to adopt it. Ozow launched a shared [bank application-programming-interface rail with FNB and RMB](#), its fourth such arrangement, and Pepkor announced a [R21.3bn merger of Flash and Shop2Shop](#), subject to approval.

## Governance and regulation

The Electronic Communications Amendment Bill was published, [exempting community networks from licensing](#) and mandating spectrum sharing; submissions close on 21 August. The minister [backed the regulator](#) in the review application brought by the two largest mobile operators against the data bundle roll-over rules. The Angolan kwanza became the [second settlement currency on the SADC real-time system](#), the first addition since 2013. Afreximbank and the Industrial Development Corporation signed a three-year memorandum against an [\\$8bn envelope](#); no pipeline, schedule or risk split was disclosed.

## Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

The Department of Communications and Digital Technologies stated on 29 July that the redrafted national AI policy [will issue guidelines rather than prescribe rules](#), and that the seven institutions proposed in the withdrawn draft are being reconsidered; cabinet consideration is targeted for November 2026, with January 2027 as fallback. On 31 July the chair of Parliament's communications portfolio committee stated her [opposition to creating new AI regulators](#).

The Prudential Authority's 2025/26 report, reported on 16 July, [embeds AI, cloud, cyber and data-offshoring into bank supervision](#) and records a first nationwide AI-adoption survey naming regulatory uncertainty, AI skills and governance as the barriers. A dedicated framework is expected in 2026; none is published.

The Labour Court [stayed disciplinary proceedings](#) against three municipal employees on prima facie evidence that a ruling relied on authorities that do not exist. SARS disclosed that [100% of verification cases and 88.41% of complex audits](#) are selected by automated risk assessment. Home Affairs reported that its electronic travel authorisation had [refused more than 5,500 travellers](#) since October 2025. Huawei reported [1,400 local partners accounting for 94.7% of its local revenue](#) at its Sandton partner event, where South Africa's founding membership of the China-led World AI Cooperation Organisation was noted; the figures are company-reported.

## Inclusion, capacity and finance

The South African Social Security Agency [set 350,000 grant reviews for 2026/27](#) against a projected R1.5bn saving, while beneficiaries flagged from September 2025 [reported continued non-payment](#). An account of the digitalised grants system published on 25 July set out the [bank-account means test applied across eight grants](#), which remains in operation under appeal, with the Supreme Court of Appeal hearing set for 25 August 2026. Gold Cards were confirmed to [cease functioning after 31 August](#); the position of beneficiaries who miss the deadline was not stated. The information technology sector education and training authority was [referred for a governance assessment](#), and Telkom committed [R100m to an AI institute](#).

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